

1 Corinthians 15:4 reads like this: “and that He was buried, and that He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures”. “The Scriptures” here presumably refers to the Gospels, because “on the third day” is not to be found in the OT. Did you get that? Since “on the third day” is not in the OT, the reference is to the Gospels, presumably.

In John 2:22 I would translate, “so they believed the Scripture, even the word that Jesus had spoken”—what Jesus said in John 2:19 was already circulating as ‘Scripture’ in Matthew 26:61 and 27:40 (when John wrote, in 62 AD).

Clement of Rome, whose first letter to the Corinthians is usually dated about AD 96, made liberal use of Scripture, appealing to its authority, and used New Testament material right alongside Old Testament material. Clement quoted Psalm 118:18 and Hebrews 12:6 side by side as “the holy word” (56:3-4).¹ He ascribes 1 Corinthians to “the blessed Paul the apostle” and says of it, “with true inspiration he wrote to you” (47:1-3). He clearly quotes from Hebrews, 1 Corinthians and Romans and possibly from Matthew, Acts, Titus, James and 1 Peter. Here is the bishop of Rome, before the close of the first century, writing an official letter to the church at Corinth wherein a selection of New Testament books are recognized and declared by episcopal authority to be Scripture, including Hebrews (and involving at least five different authors).

The Epistle of Barnabas, variously dated from AD 70 to 135, says in 4:14, “let us be careful lest, as it is written, it should be found with us that ‘many are called but few chosen’.” The reference seems to be to Matthew 22:14 (or 20:16) and the phrase “as it is written” may fairly be taken as a technical expression referring to Scripture. In 5:9 there is a quote from Matthew 9:13 (or Mark 2:17 or Luke 5:32). In 13:7 there is a loose quote from Romans 4:11-12, which words are put in God’s mouth. Similarly, in 15:4 we find: “Note, children, what ‘he ended in six days’ means. It means this: that the Lord will make an end of everything in six thousand years,

¹ I am aware that it could be Proverbs 3:12 (LXX) rather than Hebrews 12:6. Clement quotes from both books repeatedly throughout the letter, so they are equal candidates on that score. But, Clement agrees verbatim with Hebrews while Proverbs (LXX) differs in one important word. Further, the main point of Clement's chapter 56 is that correction is to be received graciously and as from the Lord, which is also the point of Hebrews 12:3-11. Since Clement evidently had both books in front of him (in the next chapter he quotes nine consecutive verses, Proverbs 1:23-31) the verbatim agreement with Hebrews is significant. If he deliberately chose the wording of Hebrews over that of Proverbs, what might that imply about their rank?